

Christopher Wren

Although best known as an architect, Sir Christopher Wren (1632–1723) was also an expert in anatomy, astronomy, mathematics, geometry, mechanics, biology and optics. After founding the Royal Society and reading Vitruvius, he took an interest in architecture and in 1665 visited Bernini in Paris. At the time, the profession of architect did not formally exist, and it was not unusual for well-educated gentlemen to take it up as a branch of mathematics. His first project was the chapel of Pembroke College in Cambridge, commissioned by his uncle, the bishop of Ely, in 1663, but he is remembered best for St Paul's Cathedral (1674–1710). He had been involved in repairing the old cathedral since 1661, and in 1666 he designed a dome for it – but within a week, the Great Fire destroyed the building along with most of London. So Wren designed a new cathedral, along with the entire City of London, including several new churches. Wren also built the Sheldonian Theatre in Oxford (1663), the Royal Hospital at Greenwich (opposite, 1696–1742), and the Wren Library at Trinity College, Cambridge (1676–84).

